

CS 8803/4803 Sociotechnical Security

Semester Project Mid-point Report Guidelines

Georgia Tech, Fall 2026

Introduction

Over the course of the semester, you will work in groups of 1–3 people to conduct original research in Sociotechnical Security. This document details what you will need to submit for your mid-point report. **If you are working as part of a team, submit as a group on Gradescope**

This 2-3 page report should demonstrate your understanding of the problem you are working on, explain your methodological planning, and show the progress you have made toward your final deliverables. The more work you do ahead of this time, the more Veronica can help you.

This report is worth 10% of your grade. It will be evaluated on clarity, how well you have positioned your problem within prior academic work, and methodological soundness (e.g., is it clear what you will accomplish, have you taken adequate measures to ensure successful data collection).

You should use either the USENIX Security Overleaf template ([Overleaf v.2023](#)) or the Word template ([Word v.2022](#)) for your proposal. This is the same template as project proposal, so feel free to edit your previous document. You can continue editing this document for your final report as well.

Your submission must include the following four sections (at a minimum).

Introduction

The introduction should set the stage for your project and communicate **why** it matters. Readers of your report should understand your research motivation within a few paragraphs. Please include the following:

- **Problem Statement:** Clearly describe the problem that your project addresses. You can use both academic and mainstream media articles to highlight the point.
- **Motivation and Significance:** Explain why this issue is important in the broader landscape of sociotechnical security; it's not enough to say that there's an issue, you need to try to get people to care about the issue. Consider answering questions like: (a) what specific user group(s) are most affected? (b) how does this problem intersect with security, privacy, or well-being? (c) Why is this problem understudied, misunderstood, or technically challenging to address? (d) what is at stake if we do not examine this problem?
- **Scope and Project:** Tightly define the boundaries of your study. By this, you should clarify what you are measuring, designing, or evaluating. You should clearly state what is out of scope as well. For example, "*We focus on user-to-user harassment reports on mid-sized platforms*" or "*Our prototype targets recovery from financial control abuse, not detection*".
- **Project Outcomes:** End with a short sneakpeak of what you aim to contribute (e.g., a measurement framework, prototype, typology, or set of policy recommendations).

Related Work

The Related Work section positions your project within the existing scholarly and industry landscape; some of which we may have covered in the lectures. It should demonstrate your awareness of what has been done already by existing scholars, and where your work contributes something new. Don't get too caught up on introducing something completely new (as this can be hard), but explain how your approach might not have been considered by other people before. Good related work sections are selective, analytical, and integrative; not just summaries of prior papers. What to include:

- **Core Sources:** Cite at least 3–5 relevant (academic or gray literature) works, ideally mixing peer-reviewed papers, industry reports, or credible white papers (e.g., from platforms, non-governmental organizations, or research institutes). This is exploring if you’ve done your reading beforehand and have some sensitivity to who is already conducting research in this area. For each source, briefly explain what it contributes (is it a method you’d like to copy, empirical data you want to build on?) and how it informs the direction of your own project. For example: *“Thomas et al. (2021) categorize hate and harassment typologies, but our project intends to apply this framework to understand scams on moderated livestream platforms”*
- **Identify Gaps:** To identify a “gap”, you should state how your project builds upon, extends, or contradicts others who have done work in this space. For instance, you might be testing an assumption (e.g., how safe are child safety features on Meta?), or highlighting that there are gaps in existing datasets in relation to hate and harassment. See if you can bridge this approach with a short paragraph which connects this literature to the methods you’ve chosen to use. For example: *“These studies emphasize individual harms, but our project focuses on relational ones between families.”*

Research Plan & Current Status

This section describes what work you have already done on your project and what lies ahead. **It will not be graded on how far ahead in your project you are.** So, be honest, realistic, specific, and self-reflective. This can mean acknowledging both what has gone well and where guidance is needed. If you’ve run into challenges, feel free to describe how you have navigated them and where you still need guidance. What to include:

- **Research questions or objectives:** Restate your guiding research questions or goals that structure your work. These help to anchor you to what you are trying to answer by the time you present and hand in your final report in December.
- **Methodological approach:** Describe your planned or current methods, namely, how you are going to approach data collection, prototype design, implement an audit study of specific platform features, or policy review. Try to be as specific as possible, such as including sample characteristics, how you are going to use specific tooling to explore your problem space, or the platforms you have chosen to study. If your methods have changed between now and the proposal, state a justification as for why; it’s okay to change your mind or approach on things!
- **Progress to date:** Summarize your specific accomplishments so far, ideally with documenting evidence of their completion. For example, if you are conducting interviews, attach your interview protocol; if you are making a prototype, share a link to your GitHub Repo.

Timeline

Outline what remains (e.g., further recruitment, data analysis, reporting drafting, etc) and set deadlines for when you expect to complete each of these by (realistically). Please make sure to note any ethical, technical, or logistical barriers you might face and how you plan to address them. This will help Veronica prepare for the check-in meeting.